

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

Document-Based Question

US.43 — Describe the impact of the Great Depression on the American people, including mass unemployment, migration, and Hoovervilles.

US.44 — Describe the steps taken by President Herbert Hoover to address the depression, including his philosophy of “Rugged Individualism,” public works projects, the Reconstruction Finance Corporation, and response to the “Bonus Army.”

US.45 — Analyze the impact of the relief, recovery, and reform efforts of President Franklin D. Roosevelt’s New Deal programs, including: • Agricultural Adjustment Act • Civilian Conservation Corps • Securities and Exchange Commission • Fair Labor Standards Act • Social Security • Federal Deposit Insurance • Tennessee Valley Authority • Works Progress Administration • National Recovery Administration

TEACHER EDITION — scoring guide and expected evidence. Not for student distribution.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

Directions. Analyze the three primary sources below. Then respond to the prompt using evidence from ALL THREE documents and your own historical knowledge.

The sources

Document A

Tennessee Valley Authority Act, Section 1, May 18, 1933 (National Archives, public domain)

“Be it enacted...for the especial purpose of bringing about in said Tennessee Valley and adjoining territory...the maximum amount of flood control; the maximum development of said Tennessee River for navigation purposes; the maximum generation of electric power consistent with flood control and navigation; the proper use of marginal lands; the proper method of reforestation of all lands in said drainage basin suitable for reforestation; and the economic and social well-being of the people living in said river basin.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT A

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document B

FDR Message to Congress Recommending Establishment of the TVA, April 10, 1933 (FDR Presidential Library, public domain)

“It is clear that the Muscle Shoals development is but a small part of the potential public usefulness of the entire Tennessee River...if we are careful and far-sighted, we can make it serve as a model for the whole nation... I suggest that this power development of war days be used not merely as an opportunity for the comfort and happiness of adjoining States but as a means of planning for the improvement of the broadest of physical, social, and economic conditions in the whole of the territory.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT B

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

Document C

Statement of Wendell Willkie, President of Commonwealth and Southern Corporation (private utility), opposing TVA expansion, Congressional testimony, 1933 (Congressional Record, public domain)

“The Tennessee Valley Authority is entering into direct competition with established private industry which has made enormous investments in good faith under the laws of the land. The power business is not a natural monopoly...The government should not compete with private enterprise in the distribution of electric power. This is not a question of power rates; it is a question of whether the government of the United States is going to socialize the electric utility industry.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT C

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

The question

PROMPT: Using all three documents and your knowledge of the Tennessee Valley Authority (1933-1941) and the broader New Deal debate, construct an argument that answers: To what extent did the TVA represent a new model for the relationship between the federal government and regional economic development

1. and why was it so ideologically contested? In your response, you MUST:

1. Analyze each document using the HIPP framework

2. identify at least ONE HIPP element for each document (historical context, intended audience, purpose, or point of view). 2. Identify the purpose and scope of the TVA as presented in Documents A and B, and explain what made this vision of federal intervention genuinely new. 3. Evaluate Willkie's critique (Document C) using historical evidence

3. was his characterization of the TVA as 'socialization' accurate, and what does this debate reveal about the limits of the New Deal consensus? 4. Use at least two pieces of outside historical knowledge to strengthen your argument about the TVA's historical significance in Tennessee and nationally

Plan your answer

Your claim	
------------	--

Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document A		
Document B		
Document C		

Outside knowledge		
----------------------	--	--

Write your response

Scoring guide

Pts	6-point scale
6	Exemplary. All three documents analyzed with precise HIPP elements accurately contextualized. Argument clearly addresses the newness of the TVA model and the ideological contestation with specific historical detail. Uses all three documents as evidence. Evaluates Willkie's critique with nuance — neither dismissing it entirely nor accepting it uncritically. At least two pieces of accurate outside knowledge strengthen the argument. Writing is historically rigorous and well-organized.
5	Advanced. Three documents analyzed with HIPP (one element may be less developed). Argument addresses both newness and contestation. Uses all three documents and at least one outside fact. Evaluation of Willkie's critique is present with reasonable analysis.
4	Proficient. Two documents analyzed with HIPP. Argument addresses the question with evidence from at least two documents and one outside fact. Analysis of Willkie's critique is present but may be one-dimensional.
3	Adequate. At least two documents referenced with some HIPP analysis. Argument is present but may focus on one aspect (newness OR contestation, not both). Some outside knowledge.
2	Developing. One or two documents referenced with minimal analysis. Argument is vague or incomplete. Little outside knowledge.
1	Beginning. One document summarized without analysis. No argument constructed. No HIPP analysis.
0	No response or completely off-topic.

Expected evidence and document analysis. DOCUMENT ANALYSIS EXPECTATIONS: - Doc A: Purpose = multi-mandate federal agency; Context = Depression-era Tennessee Valley - Doc B: Audience = Congress; Purpose = frame TVA as national model; Context = First Hundred Days - Doc C: POV = private utility / free-market ideology; Purpose = lobby against TVA; Context = threat to Commonwealth and Southern profits KEY EVIDENCE EXPECTED: Norris Dam (1936, Tennessee); rural electrification rates in East Tennessee; Ashwander v. TVA (1936); Muscle Shoals (WWI nitrate plant, TVA anchor); electricity rates before and after TVA; Tennessee Valley poverty statistics 1930s; Rural Electrification Administration (1935); TVA as 'yardstick' for measuring private utility rates. TENNESSEE SPECIFIC CONNECTION: The TVA is directly centered on the Tennessee River and its tributaries across Tennessee and neighboring states. Norris Dam in Anderson/Campbell counties, Tennessee was the first TVA dam. This item has direct and accurate Tennessee historical content.

Sourcing. Every document above carries its own citation as written in the item record. Verify each against the holding institution before classroom use — an unsourced primary source is worse than a missing one.

History Hack · TroopToTeacher Technologies. Tennessee Academic Standards 2027-28. classroom-formative · pre-field-test — this activity has not been field-tested and its scoring guide is not calibrated.